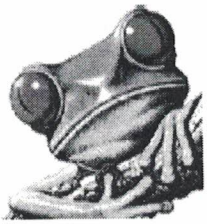
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Papa Oscar



ISSN 1544-1423

By David Ralph

TEASER

When I was thirteen, I hated everything there was to hate. I hated school. I hated life. I hated my mom for being such a sea-hag. I used to love baseball when my dad coached my little league team, but then he left when I was ten, so I hated that too.

In those days, my routine consisted of skipping class, hating, picking fights, hating, shoplifting, hating, and did I mention hating? I wanted to prove that I was the toughest kid in town; I actually had it in my mind that I was one of those criminal types that everyone loved, like Al Capone. I could see the headlines, "Beloved Criminal Goes Down in a Hail of Bullets."

But then my life started to change when I met Papa Oscar.

END TEASER

I was busted. I wanted the new "Ozzie" CD mainly because my mom would turn the station if he came on the radio, yelling at it as if he could hear her, "Devil worshipers!" Devil worshiping wasn't my thing but I wanted to hear an entire song. Plus, I loved the way his raspy screaming and the loud electric guitars smashed together like two rams in a fight for dominance. Besides, anything that ticked my mom off was an extra bonus.

Later that night I made my way to the music aisle at Walmart. After a quick glance around, I slowly pried the CD out of the plastic covering that held it tightly in place and then shot like a hyperactive gerbil on a caffeine IV toward the door, but before I could put a foot into the open air, a talon-like grip grabbed me by the collar and drug me away.

"Two hundred hours of community service," smoothly boomed down on me from the slow motion mouth of the probate judge. "200" kept echoing, echoing, echoing in my mind so many times that my head began to throb. The throb was compounded when he followed up with, "To be carried out at Pine Ridge Community Care Home." Crap, I hated old people. I was forced to go to Pine Ridge once when I was in the fourth grade. We had to sing Christmas carols to the old fogies to cheer them up for the holidays, because most likely their own kids wouldn't show up to celebrate with them. Old people have a certain stench that disturbed me. They smell like a combination of urine, denture cream, Ben Gay, hair dye, fecal matter, and death. I never really got over the smell of death.

200 hours, begin countdown.

Every day after school, I was to report to Miss Plath who was the activity director at Pine Ridge. Miss Plath looked old enough to be a resident of Pine Ridge herself and acted as if she belonged in the nut house. She was constantly running around trying to get everyone involved, which was worthless in my mind; no one seemed to know where they were. She gave me the prestigious privilege and honorable duty of becoming the BINGO caller. Calling numbers sure beat the image I had of cleaning out bedpans with a tiny brush or taste testing pureed grilled cheese sandwiches. I called out numbers despite most of the geriatrics being stooped over in their wheel chairs, half asleep or waiting to die.

"B 7…B 7."

I never understood activity time. Some of the old people would be talking to themselves in words that no one could make out while many more would be screaming that they wanted to go home, all they wanted was to go home.

"I 13…I 13 and you all are about 400 years old."

His laugh was full of life and filled the room as he sat in an old red vinyl chair in the back. His chuckle would have been extremely infectious if everyone in the room had not been immunized against laughter decades ago. He obviously thought my joke was funny, but Miss Plath did not and shook her head at me as she directed me to read the next BINGO ball.

When I was ready to make my getaway the old prune with the lively laugh cut me off before I could reach the door, "You going to be back tomorrow Sammy Boy?"

"My name is Tony, and unfortunately, yes."

"Good. Good. These old fogies might start a riot Sammy boy if they don't get to hear their BINGO numbers called. You ain't seen nothin' until you see a bunch of old dried up raisins raisin' a ruckus."

He was funny. I could see a bunch of old people throwing walkers while chanting BINGO! BINGO! BINGO! I figure this senile old coot might help pass the hours.

"Do you remember me? My name is Oscar, but you called me Papa Oscar. Remember Sammy Boy?"

"Tony. I'll see you tomorrow."

"See you then Sammy Boy."

142 hours to go.

Papa Oscar soon became my biggest ally in keeping me away from Miss Plath and out of the activity room. He started making requests for me to come down and clean his room, which Miss Plath and her crazy scattered brain bought every time.

"I could strike out anyone. Anyone Sammy." By this time, I had given up on correcting Papa Oscar every time he called me Sammy and had actually gotten used to it.

"Do you still play baseball Sammy?"

I had never told Oscar I played, but at that moment, the only thought I could bring up was the day my dad left. That day I was so mad I took my glove, the one thing I treasured most, and threw it in the creek. I never wanted to play baseball again. My dad loved baseball and when he left me, I hated it. I didn't want to tell Papa Oscar why I quit playing ball so I quickly diverted his attention.

"Did you ever make it to the majors?"

"I had one year in the majors. I played for the Red Sox in '43. I watched from the bullpen as Ted Williams had one of his best years. He had a .356 batting average, slammed 36 homers, and had 137 ribbies, but I'll be damned when he got runner-up for MVP to that no-good-bum-bastard from those damn Yankees, Joe Gordon."

"Ted Williams?! Radical! Did you ever get to pitch against him in practice or anything?"

"Yep. Struck him out too. He was a sucker for the curve ball. I could strike out anyone."

"I bet you could Papa Oscar."

I wondered to myself how much a new glove would cost.

Tee minus 101 hours.

"Have a seat son. I guess it's time we have this talk. I feel like it's my obligation to explain this to you beings that you're almost a grown man now. My father told me and I think it's only right that I tell you. Son, as a man you're going to start having urges. Sexual urges."

"Uhhhh....excuse me?"

"Do you know where babies come from?"

"Ummmm." I couldn't believe what I was hearing. I knew what was what. As a defense mechanism I just started repeating, "I know, I know, I know" loud enough so I couldn't hear the lecture.

"You see Sammy, a boy has a...."

" I know, I know, I know..."

"He takes that and puts it in the woman's..."

"I know, I know..."

"Do what comes natural and bam, you got yourself a baby."

"I know."

When he had finished, his face was flushed red as was mine. I guess my ol' man should have had that talk with me instead of Papa Oscar, but he had never given me any "fatherly" advice. Both embarrassed, we sat looking out Papa Oscar's window at the birds feeding; quiet, like a father and son.

75 hours until freedom.

"I could strike out anybody. Anybody."

"Why did you only play for one year Papa Oscar?"

"When Ted left for the war, I left. Anyone that wanted to be a man did the honorable thing and joined the cause. Honor says a lot about a man Sammy."

"Yeah, well I don't know much about that."

"Man has to try his hardest at everything he does. Be honest and straightforward and always follow through on what he says he's going to do. Had I known that was the last time I was going to see you son, I would have said goodbye. It was just that...well...the ship was leaving in the middle of the night and I had to follow through with my word. I had to be a man like Ted. I just wish I had said that I love you."

Sometimes Papa Oscar would drift off and get his stories mixed up. I didn't mind much since they usually kept my attention. I had learned to play along since my mind seemed to be as perfectly random as his was. But this time his face was sad and lonely; he had temporarily lost

the spark for life in his body that I had seen the first day we met. I tried to bring him back to reality.

"Is that what happened to your hand, fighting in the war?"

"Yes sir, lost my fingers from shrapnel."

"Could you play for the Sox when you got back?"

"No sir, I got an education instead and became a school teacher. If you get hurt during war, the military sure will give you a lot of money."

"Teacher? I can't talk to you anymore; just kidding."

I could see Papa Oscar as a school teacher when he was younger, but he wouldn't have been like mine were. He would have been a teacher who would always tell great stories and keep his students interested. I could see him teaching something like history or philosophy. Papa Oscar was the best teacher I ever had.

15 hours.

"I'm glad you're here."

"I'm here Papa Oscar. Sorry I'm a little late. Crazy Plath made me play beanbag catch with all the old fogies. I tried to get away as soon as I could. I figured you and I could convince the others to turn activity time into the Grumpy Old Farts World Series."

"I just don't want to be alone, Sammy. This place gets so lonely."

"I'm here. Hey, are you feeling ok?"

"I'm glad you're here."

"I'm glad I'm here too."

1 hour.

"Hey, Sammy Boy good to see ya."

"What are you looking at Papa Oscar?"

"I can remember that day like it was yesterday. I'll never forget it. Can you remember it Sammy?"

Papa Oscar handed me an old black and white photo of a house that must have been his before he left for the war. In front of the house was a very attractive young woman, a boy who was about my age, and then there was what looked like a younger version of Papa Oscar. They stood as a family. I wondered if I had any pictures like that one of my family before dad left. I didn't know if I should play along with Papa Oscar this time or just play dumb, so I choose the easiest.

"Remember? " He repeated, more urgent this time.

"No sir."

"This was a couple of weeks before I left for the war; one of the last days I saw you. Your mom didn't want me to go. I didn't have to go but I gave my word. I gave my word son. Pride can be an evil thing. When I came back, she wouldn't let me see you and I didn't want to see her. All because of stupid pride. Always forgive son. So, you understand me? Always forgive."

"Yes sir."

"Sorry I missed your birthday. I got you a present. Tell you're mom I'm sorry. I made a mistake. I'm sorry son. Sammy?"

"Yes Papa?"

"Do you forgive me son?"

"Yes Papa."

"I love you."

I quickly turned to the gift trying to ignore Papa's last statement. I hated love. My father used to say that to my mother and me and then he left. I watched the gift as if it were going to jump off Papa Oscar's dresser. On top of the gift was a card that said "Sammy Boy." My birthday was six months ago so I knew the gift was not really for me. I remembered the old black and white picture he had just shown me. I knew the gift was for Sammy, Oscar's real son, the one in the picture, the one he would never see again. I looked at the yellowed, antique wrapping paper and thought about when my mother's father died. My mom kept saying he was going to die soon because he kept telling everyone his entire life story. He was telling people his story so that he could be remembered when he passed on. He knew his time was coming. The whole time I had known Papa Oscar, I had never seen anyone talk to him. I had never seen a family member in his room. He was like me, always by himself and acting as if he didn't want to talk to anyone. Maybe that's why we got along so well; he needed me as much as I needed him. I needed a father as much as he needed a son.

Papa Oscar's eyes closed as his smile slowly sank down on his face and finally settled on a small smirk. His recliner stopped rocking. His body peacefully rested itself. I sat in the silence without moving. I sat in the stillness of the room and thought of my own father. I knew my dad's phone number; I hadn't wanted to talk to him, but while watching Papa Oscar, my dad's voice was the only one I wanted to hear.

Papa Oscar could finally let go. He was in a better place.

"I love you too." I whispered.

I sat there for what remained of my final hour. I did a lot of thinking in that time about everything I had learned over the 200 hours I spent with Papa Oscar. Thinking that allowed all my hate to evaporate. Thinking that changed my life.

That was more than 25 years ago and I can recount it as if it were yesterday. I never found the real Sammy Boy. Too bad as I would have liked to share his father's last words. I laid my own father to rest two years ago but not before we had shared many happy years together. I learned to forgive, and to love. I'm now a school teacher and live in Kansas with my beautiful wife and thirteen-year-old son. My son is quite the ball player. Both my wife and I enjoy watching Oscar play on the weekends. He's a great kid.

Tibetan Treefrog Publishing
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Fort Scott, KS 66701
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